

Caring for Your Mental Health

National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH)

Source: <https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

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Overview

Mental health includes emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It is more than the absence of a mental illness—it's essential to your overall health and quality of life. Self-care can play a role in maintaining your mental health and help support your treatment and recovery if you have a mental illness.

How can I take care of my mental health?

Self-care means taking the time to do things that help you live well and improve both your physical health and mental health. This can help you manage stress, lower your risk of illness, and increase your energy. Even small acts of self-care in your daily life can have a big impact.

- Get regular exercise. Just 30 minutes of walking every day can boost your mood and improve your health. Small amounts of exercise add up.
- Eat healthy, regular meals and stay hydrated. A balanced diet and plenty of water can improve your energy and focus throughout the day.
- Make sleep a priority. Stick to a schedule and make sure you're getting enough sleep. Reduce blue light exposure before bedtime.
- Try a relaxing activity. Consider meditation, muscle relaxation, breathing exercises, music, reading, time in nature, or low-stress hobbies.
- Set goals and priorities. Decide what must get done now and what can wait. Learn to say no to new tasks when you are taking on too much.
- Practice gratitude. Remind yourself daily of things you are grateful for. Write them down or replay them in your mind.
- Focus on positivity. Identify and challenge negative and unhelpful thoughts.
- Stay connected. Reach out to friends or family members who can provide emotional support and practical help.

Self-care looks different for everyone, and it is important to find what you need and enjoy. It may take trial and error to discover what works best for you.

When should I seek professional help?

Seek professional help if you are experiencing severe or distressing symptoms that have lasted 2 weeks or more, such as:

- Difficulty sleeping
- Changes in appetite or unplanned weight changes
- Difficulty getting out of bed in the morning because of mood
- Difficulty concentrating

- Loss of interest in things you usually find enjoyable
- Inability to complete usual tasks and activities
- Feelings of irritability, frustration, or restlessness

How can I find help?

If you have concerns about your mental health, talk to a primary care provider. They can refer you to a qualified mental health professional, such as a psychologist, psychiatrist, or clinical social worker, who can help you figure out the next steps.

If you or someone you know is struggling or having thoughts of suicide, call or text the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline at 988 or chat at 988lifeline.org. This service is confidential, free, and available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. In life-threatening situations, call 911.

Suicide is preventable—learn about warning signs of suicide and action steps for helping someone in emotional distress.

Learn more

NIH Wellness Toolkits; MedlinePlus: How to Improve Mental Health; CDC: Emotional Well-Being; SAMHSA: How to Cope; VA Office of Mental Health: Veteran Training.

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